COMMON GROUND

Immigrant Entrepreneurship, Community Space, and the Coffee Shops of Ocean Avenue

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THE RESEARCH QUESTION

Three immigrant-owned cafés share one street. Each one was built with an explicit community mission. Does that mission hold, and what does it depend on?

- Three coffee shops sharing one street in San Francisco's Ingleside neighborhood
- Each founded by immigrants or children of immigrants
- Each with an explicit mission to create community—not just commerce

"Cities have the capability of providing something for everybody, only because, and only when, they are created by everybody." — Jane Jacobs, 1961

CONTEXT

Three Cafés, One Street

Java on Ocean

Est. 1999

Lebanese immigrant family

“A place where everyone belongs”

Java On Ocean Coffee House offers a cozy and welcoming atmosphere with plenty of seating, live plants, and light music. Known to locals for their friendly staff and service.

Diamond Coffee N’ Pastry

Est. 2025 (8 months old)

Immigrant-owned, Ingleside

Community-building vision in early formation

Diamond Coffee n’ Pastry is a locally owned coffee and pastry shop. They provide “mixed cultural” pastries, pour over coffee, espresso and specialty drinks.

Philz Coffee

Est. 2003 (Mission District)

Phil Jaber — son of Palestinian immigrants

“A cup of love” — handcrafted hospitality

Philz Coffee is a coffeehouse chain based in San Francisco, and has 75 locations across the country. Philz focuses on making pour over coffee.

LITERATURE REVIEW

Immigrant Entrepreneurship

Beyond survival — toward community infrastructure

Mixed Embeddedness

Kloosterman & Rath, 2001

Immigrant entrepreneurs are embedded in two worlds simultaneously: ethnic social networks that supply trust, labor, and capital; the host country's socioeconomic structure that sets the rules of the market.

This dual embeddedness shapes not only business viability but the social texture of the spaces they create.

Ethnic Economies

Light & Gold, 2000

Immigrant-owned businesses do more than generate income. They maintain neighborhood stability, provide entry-level training for co-ethnics, and build political and social power for communities otherwise excluded from mainstream institutions.

The business is not separate from the community; it is community infrastructure.

LITERATURE REVIEW

Cafés as Community Space

Where this research began

Café as Community Space

Ferreira, 2021

Ferreira's study reframes the urban café as an institution of social production rather than a site of consumption. Cafés scaffold the informal social infrastructure of neighborhoods: repeated, low-stakes encounters between regulars constitute the fabric of everyday community life. The business, she finds, is inseparable from the belonging it generates.

Third Places

Mimoun & Gruen, 2021

Mimoun and Gruen distinguish between connective third places, where meaningful social bonds form, and productive ones, where people coexist without relating. A café can be full of people and empty of community. What determines which it becomes is a function of design, staffing, and the culture of ownership.

Urban Multiculture & Everyday Encounters

Jones et al., 2015

Jones and colleagues document the "mundane conviviality" of multicultural urban spaces: the ordinary, daily contact across difference that makes a neighborhood work. They found immigrant-owned businesses to be especially good at generating it. Places where difference becomes unremarkable, where no one must announce that they belong. The regulars who share the same corner, week after week, are not performing inclusion. They are simply building a neighborhood.

LITERATURE REVIEW

The Third Place

Informal public gathering spaces beyond home and work

The Great Good Place

Oldenburg, 1989

Oldenburg identifies a third category of social life beyond home and work: informal gathering spaces like cafés, barbershops, corner stores are characterized by neutral ground, social leveling, conversation, and accessibility to all.

These “great good places” are, he argues, the heart of a community’s social vitality. A neighborhood without them is not a neighborhood, it is a collection of addresses. Their decline from American public life marks the erosion of civic connection itself.

Third Places & Community Quality of Life

Jeffres et al., 2009

Jeffres and colleagues find that access to third places is a statistically significant predictor of community satisfaction. Neighborhoods with active third places report stronger social ties, greater civic participation, and higher perceived quality of life.

The effect is especially pronounced in ethnically diverse urban neighborhoods where formal civic institutions are less accessible or unapproachable. This framing makes the corner café not a luxury but a structural necessity.

LITERATURE REVIEW

Social Capital & Place-Making

What do third places produce — and for whom?

Bonding & Bridging Capital

Putnam, 2000

Social capital comes in two forms: bonding capital and bridging capital. Bonding capital is dense ties within a community, and bridging capital is connection across groups that build broader civic trust.

Third places function as engines of bridging capital. The stranger who returns found cash, the CCSF classmates sharing a café with retirees. These low-stakes cross-group encounters are, over time, what holds a diverse neighborhood together.

Urban Authenticity & Place-Making

Zukin, 2010; Jacobs, 1961

Sharon Zukin argues that neighborhood authenticity is not architectural, it is produced by the long-running small businesses that anchor a street's social memory and resist the uniformity of chain retail.

Immigrant-owned cafés perform this work even more: they anchor neighborhood identity, hold community memory, and model a vision of public life rooted in hospitality rather than transaction. The café is not just a business in this sense, it is a form of infrastructure.

METHODS

Ethnographic Field Observation

Field Sites

- Java on Ocean
  March 23, 2026 (2.5 hrs)
- Philz Coffee
  April 6, 2026 (1 hr)
- Diamond Coffee N' Pastry
  April 7, 2026 (1 hr)

Data Sources

- Typed fieldnotes
- Patron and interaction counts
- Local journalism (Ingleside Light, Local News Matters, Mission Local)
- Peer-reviewed academic literature

Analytic Approach

- Comparative ethnography across three sites
- Thematic coding of fieldnotes
- Sociological frameworks applied to observed data

PART ONE

The Research

Three sites. What we observed.

JAVA ON OCEAN

The Space















JAVA ON OCEAN

Field Notes

March 23, 2026 · 11:15 AM – 1:44 PM · 1700 Ocean Ave

Date: March 23, 2026 **Time:** 11:15 AM – 1:44 PM **Location:** Java on Ocean 1700 Ocean Ave, San Francisco, CA **Observer:** Anna Danielson **Conditions:** Weekday, lunchtime. Warm and sunny, 67°F.

11:15 AM — Initial Observations

Upon arrival, the café had approximately 20 patrons, with nearly all tables occupied. The atmosphere was lively and loud, with conversation dominating the soundscape and music playing softly in the background.

Seating and group composition:

- 3 tables with groups of 3 or more engaged in conversation
- 2 tables with pairs
- 5 patrons seated alone
- 1 person seated at an outdoor table
- 2 patrons placed takeout orders shortly after my arrival

Solo patron activities:

- 1 man reading a book
- 2 patrons working on laptops
- 1 patron using a phone
- 1 patron reading on a tablet with headphones

Demographics:

12:01 PM

[personal details removed]

Additional observations during this period:

- A woman who was present at the time of my arrival remained seated, now wearing headphones, having removed her shoes and sitting cross-legged
- 1 patron conducting a phone or video meeting
- Denim clothing (pants and jackets) appeared notably prevalent among patrons
- 1 man using a walker entered the café
- 1 patron discovered a sum of cash on the floor and returned it to the cashier unprompted

[personal details removed]

1:37 PM

- 10 patrons total; 9 women, 1 man
- 4 patrons working on laptops, all women

Departed: 1:44 PM

Summary

The café drew a mixed crowd ranging from approximately their late 20s to early 70s. Foot traffic was highest between 11:00 AM and 12:30 PM. Roughly half of patrons appeared focused on

DIAMOND COFFEE N' PASTRY

The Space















DIAMOND COFFEE N' PASTRY

Field Notes

April 7, 2026 · 11:21 AM – 12:21 PM · 1181 Ocean Ave

Date: April 7, 2026 **Time:** 11:21 AM – 12:21 PM **Location:** Diamond Coffee N' Pastry, 1181 Ocean Ave, San Francisco **Observer:** Anna Danielson **Conditions:** Weekday, early lunchtime. Sunny and almost chilly, approximately 57°F.

11:21 AM — Initial Observations

Upon arrival, 11 patrons including the observer, with 3 tables open. The atmosphere was calm and moderately social — a departure from Philz's study-hall silence, though not approaching Java's conversational energy.

Seating and group composition:

- 3 tables of 2 patrons each
- Of the three pairs: 1 working on laptops together; 2 chatting and laughing
- 2 patrons working on laptops independently
- 1 patron on phone with headphones
- 2 patrons waiting for orders

Demographics:

- Racially diverse
- Age range mixed, concentrated in the 20s–30s; possibly 1 high school-aged couple
- 2 baristas on shift

Physical environment:

- Stone and cement walls with wood and gold accents; a mountain shape outlined in gold below the front window
- Ceiling open-vented (warehouse feel), softened by fabric sheets draped strategically to
- Menu laminated and displayed on counter
- Plants appeared artificial
- Light mellow pop music playing in the background
- Dog water bowl on the floor near the entrance; dog treats at the counter; free Diamond cartoon stickers available at the register

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11:26 AM

Three patrons departed with to-go orders in the five minutes since arrival. Turnover appeared brisk at this hour.

11:36 AM

Five open tables — two more than at arrival. Four to five additional patrons had come in to order. The owner did not appear to be present. Note: this observer visited Diamond approximately six months prior, shortly after its August 2025 grand opening; the same two baristas were working that day and were working again today, suggesting staff continuity from early in the café's life.

Additional observations:

- 1 man conducting a meeting on headphones, speaking at a normal volume
- 1 couple conversing in Spanish
- 1 couple working intensely — both with tablets open, hunched over work, ring binders and notebooks spread on the table

PHILZ COFFEE

The Space















PHILZ COFFEE

Field Notes

April 6, 2026 · 11:50 AM – 12:50 PM · 1110 Ocean Ave

Date: April 6, 2026 **Time:** 11:50 AM – 12:50 PM **Location:** Philz Coffee 1110 Ocean Ave, San Francisco, CA 94112 **Observer:** Anna Danielson **Conditions:** Weekday, lunchtime. Overcast, approximately 58°F.

11:50 AM — Initial Observations

Upon arrival, the café had approximately 20 patrons, with most tables occupied. The atmosphere was quiet and focused, with little ambient conversation. Music played softly in the background.

Seating and group composition:

- 3–4 large communal tables, most occupied by individuals working independently
- 1 pair engaged in conversation
- The majority of patrons were seated alone

Patron activities:

- Most patrons working on laptops
- Approximately 5 patrons on phones
- 1 patron eating a packed lunch
- 4 patrons ordered food alongside their drinks
- Approximately 5 patrons wearing headphones over the course of the visit

Demographics:

- 9 men, 11 women (not including baristas)
- Food options: pastries, burritos, sandwiches, bagels, and grab-and-go items including cheese and yogurt
- A chalkboard listing the current special; to-go coffee boxes available
- A small bookshelf holding approximately 20 books and a stack of newspapers — including one from the UESF Strike (February 11, 2026) and an issue of *The Guardsman*, the City College newspaper (March 19–April 8, 2026)
- A "Philz Puppy Palz ♥" board featuring polaroid photos of customers and staff with their dogs
- LGBTQ flag displayed prominently

12:00 PM

Three patrons had placed orders and departed since my arrival. Seven additional patrons entered between 12:00 and 12:07, and four more by 12:11, offset by a handful of departures.

Additional observations during this period:

- Two patrons arrived together to study Spanish
- Three of my classmates from CCSF were present; it became apparent that much of the current crowd was drawn from City College, with many patrons having books, notepads, and study materials out
- 1 man arrived with a baby in a detachable car seat and settled in with a croissant
- A couple entered carrying a Whole Foods bag and wearing backpacks; another couple arrived and began chatting
- An older gentleman entered wearing a pink beret and took a seat at one of the communal tables
- 1 woman had a lengthy exchange with the cashier, concluding by gifting her what appeared to be a pink and purple pen, which the cashier received warmly

PART TWO

The Findings

What the research tells us.

FINDING 1

Community Is the Business

Each started with people. The business came second.

JAVA ON OCEAN

“A place where everyone belongs”

Hossam Halawani has spent 25 years greeting regulars by name and anticipating their orders before they reach the counter. The café functions as a social node: on one visit, a patron’s friend ran into her parents, who ran into several other acquaintances. This is the accumulated result of deliberate, daily hospitality.

Kloosterman & Rath (2001): immigrant entrepreneurs embedded in ethnic networks and urban markets simultaneously — for these founders, their social commitment and their business strategy are not in tension. They are the same thing.

DIAMOND COFFEE N’ PASTRY

“My dream was to have a business at the place where I grew up.”

Wayne Situ arrived from China at age 10 and came of age on Ocean Avenue when he attended City College of San Francisco, whose campus sits at the heart of the Ingleside. Diamond is his return to that corner of the city. His employees all live blocks from each other. The camping theme, the dog bowl, the free stickers — every detail is deliberate: the hospitality of someone who knows what it means to be welcomed somewhere and wants to offer the same.

PHILZ COFFEE

“A cup of love”

“I grew up watching my father run a corner store in the Mission. He knew everyone. I wanted that, but bigger.” Phil Jaber built a national brand on his father’s model of radical hospitality — the belief that selling coffee and knowing your community are not separate acts but the same one. That mission now faces its sharpest test: the brand has been sold to private equity, and corporate ownership ordered LGBTQ pride flags removed from all locations. The community backlash was swift and illuminating. When corporate ownership changes who a space is for, it changes what the space means. The community that built that space meaning notices first.

FINDING 2

Java on Ocean — What Twenty-Five Years Builds

Field Observations

- 20 patrons; nearly all tables occupied at 11:15 AM on a weekday lunchtime
- Hossam anticipated orders and greeted regulars by name before they reached the counter
- One woman, who was there upon arrival, had shoes off, sitting cross-legged 45 minutes later
- A patron found cash on the floor and returned it to the cashier unprompted
- Several patrons carried personal mugs for refills. Community membership very visible
- Gender shifted: roughly equal at noon → 9 women, 1 man by 1:37 PM

Sociological Reading

The cash-return moment is Oldenburg's "leveler" in action: informal norms of honesty emerge not through rules but through the social fabric this space has built over 25 years. Personal mugs are a regulars culture made visible in objects.

The demographic shift reveals Java serves different communities at different hours. Hosting lunchtime workers, afternoon decompressers, and women meeting friends across the same day is itself evidence of a genuine third place. Everyone belongs—even if at different times.

"On a prior visit, a friend ran into her parents, who then ran into several other acquaintances. The café functions as a social node within the community." — Field Notes, March 23, 2026

FINDING 3

Diamond Coffee N' Pastry — Community in Formation

Field Observations

- 11 patrons; atmosphere calm and moderately social
- 2 of 3 pairs chatting and laughing; 1 couple spread notebooks and binders across a table
- Camping theme executed in full: straw bales, camping chairs, fabric ceiling drapes, backlit moon
- Dog water bowl at entrance, free stickers at register—small but intentional community invitations
- Same 2 baristas working as at the grand opening 6 months prior. Staff continuity from day one
- All barista-patron exchanges transactional; owner Wayne Situ not present during visit

Sociological Reading

The camping theme is doing real work: specific, memorable, and quirky enough to generate conversation between strangers—the kind of identity hook that builds a local following.

But the concrete bones of the space (walls, floors, exposed vents) resist the warmth the theme reaches for. Staff continuity from opening day is a promising foundation. Owner presence, which Situ has committed to, is the variable most likely to determine whether Diamond cultivates a true regulars culture.

"Beautiful without being cozy, designed without feeling inhabited. At 8 months old, that may simply reflect the fact that Diamond hasn't had time to become what Java has had 25 years to become." — Field Notes, April 7, 2026

FINDING 4

Philz Coffee — Proximity Without Connection

Field Observations

- 20 patrons; quiet and focused; almost no ambient conversation at lunchtime
- Mostly solitary laptop workers; approximately 5 wearing headphones
- 3 CCSF classmates present—the café is embedded in City College's daily ecosystem
- Bookshelf held UESF Strike newspaper and The Guardsman—community artifacts on display
- LGBTQ flag prominent; Philz Puppy Palz polaroid board; rotating poster wall near bathroom

Sociological Reading

Philz's design intends community — wraparound windows, communal tables, warm tones — but proximity rarely translated into connection on this visit. Mimoun & Gruen (2021) distinguish connective third places, where bonds form, from productive ones, where people coexist without relating. Philz reads as the latter: a high-functioning study commons embedded in City College's daily rhythm.

The artifacts tell a different story: a polaroid board, community newspapers, a LGBTQ flag. These signal the social commitments Phil Jaber built the brand on. But artifacts are not practice. They document an aspiration that the community built, but corporate ownership is already trying to push back on and eliminate.

"One patron slid a pen across the counter to the cashier — unrequested, easy. It was the only unprompted exchange I witnessed in an hour."
— Field Notes, April 6, 2026

FINDING 5

The Corporate Complication

Private equity can purchase a brand. It cannot purchase what built the brand.

WHAT CHANGED

- Philz Coffee sold to private equity for $145M (2025)
- Employees explicitly cut out of the equity deal
- Corporate ownership ordered LGBTQ pride flags removed from all locations
- Community backlash was swift, public, and organized

What the Response Revealed

The community backlash to the flag removal was swift and public, also it was illuminating. It confirmed that the space's meaning had been built by the people who used it, not by the brand that owned it. Phil Jaber understood this; his buyers did not.

This gap between what Philz was as a community space built on cultural hospitality, and what it is becoming as a brand asset managed by shareholders, became visible in a single moment of policy. The community's response clarified what had been at stake all along: not just excellent drip coffee but belonging. And belonging is not transferable to private equity.

"When corporate ownership orders the flags down, it isn't only a branding decision, it is a political one. It's an answer to the question: who is this space for?" — Field Analysis

ANALYSIS

Comparison Across Sites

Dimension	Java on Ocean	Diamond Coffee	Philz Coffee
Established	1999 (25+ years)	2024 (8 months)	2003 (20+ years)
Atmosphere	Lively, social, conversational	Moderately social	Quiet, focused, study-hall
Barista warmth	High (names and orders known)	Transactional only	Low; one warm exception
Third-place status	Established regulars culture	Aspirational (forming)	Individual third-place
Owner presence	Active; sets the tone	Absent this visit	Scaled to corporate
Community signals	Personal mugs, familiar faces	Camping theme, dog bowl, stickers	Puppy Palz board, LGBTQ flag, newspapers

CONCLUSIONS

01 *Immigrant entrepreneurs as community infrastructure*

On Ocean Avenue, immigrant-rooted entrepreneurs are building what Putnam (2000) calls bridging social capital: the horizontal ties between strangers that constitute civic life. Kloosterman and Rath's mixed-embeddedness framework helps explain how: embedded simultaneously in ethnic social networks and the broader urban economy, these entrepreneurs draw on both to create spaces that serve communities far wider than their own co-ethnic group. Java on Ocean is perhaps the clearest case: 25 years of daily hospitality has produced a space where informal norms of trust and care emerge not from rules, but from accumulated relationship.

02 *Third places are intentional, not accidental*

Oldenburg's third place does not emerge spontaneously from a room with chairs and espresso machines. The evidence across all three sites confirms it is constructed through deliberate design choices, through the embodied daily labor of owners who show up and know people's names, and above all through time. What Zukin (2010) calls 'authenticity' — a business that has earned its neighborhood role — cannot be manufactured or rushed. Diamond, at 8 months, is doing the right things. Whether it becomes what Java is requires years, not months, of this kind of slow-built care and community.

03 *The market threatens what the mission built*

The Philz Coffee sale is a compressed version of a tension Sharon Zukin (2010) identifies across American cities: the neighborhood institutions that produce authentic community become vulnerable to acquisition by actors who want the brand value without the social labor behind it. When private equity purchased Philz for $145M, what they acquired is the bridging capital Phil Jaber built over two decades, but without the relational commitments that generated it. Putnam's framework is clarifying here: social capital requires ongoing, embodied investment. It cannot be securitized, franchised, or transferred in a deal.

04 *Implications & limitations*

This study is limited by short observation windows and single visits to each site. An expansive approach, returning across seasons, would better capture how these spaces function under stress, and whose needs they consistently center or overlook. Future research should prioritize the accounts of owners and workers and examine how language contributes to belonging in multicultural and multilingual cafés.

What this study suggests most plainly: the corner coffee shop, often dismissed as backdrop to other social life, deserves more attention as a site of civil society. Especially in immigrant neighborhoods where formal civic institutions may be inaccessible or structurally unwelcoming.

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